MODULE 9

CASE STUDY

Superhuman: Engineering Product-Market Fit

How a founder used a survey to systematically engineer PMF — and when to keep iterating vs. launch

Prepare this case before class. Come ready to take a position.

THE SITUATION

Superhuman, 2017

Rahul Vohra has been building Superhuman (a premium email client) for three years, backed by top-tier investors. He surveys his users with the Sean Ellis PMF question: 'How would you feel if you could no longer use Superhuman?' Only 22% say 'very disappointed' — well below the 40% threshold that indicates PMF.

The product works. Investors expect a launch. Press is eager. But the data says he doesn't have PMF yet.

KEY FACTS

- Venture-backed · 3 years in development
- PMF score: 22% (threshold: 40%)
- Invite-only beta (PMF survey n≈300)
- Price: $30/month (premium positioning)
- Email client market: crowded
- Press eager to cover the launch

THE DECISION

Should Vohra launch publicly, keep iterating in private beta, or pivot?

OPTION A

Launch — you've spent $33M and 2 years. Ship it, let the market decide

OPTION B

Keep iterating — systematically improve until PMF score hits 40%

OPTION C

Pivot the positioning — maybe $30/month email is wrong; go freemium or different market

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Come prepared to defend your position with evidence from the case.

1. Is the Sean Ellis PMF survey a reliable measure? What are its limitations?
1. How do you decide what to improve when PMF score is low? What data helps?
1. What's the cost of launching without PMF vs. the cost of staying in private beta?
1. Apply the 3 R's framework: where is Superhuman weakest — Retention, Referral, or Revenue?